

KING OF FRANCE Born 1638 Died 1715

Louis XIV

“L’Etat, c’est moi.” (I am, myself, **the state**) LOUIS XIV, KING OF FRANCE

Louis XIV was only four years old in 1643, when he succeeded his father, Louis XIII, as king of France. During the regency of his mother, Anne of Austria, the effective ruler of France was her chief minister, Cardinal Mazarin. When Mazarin died in 1661, the 23-year-old King Louis XIV was expected to appoint a chief minister of similar caliber. Instead, he announced his intention of being his own first minister, and ruling as an absolute monarch (see right).

Expensive wars

For the first 20 years of his personal reign (1661–81), Louis was constantly waging war. He began with an attack on the Spanish Netherlands in 1667 to gain land, but his territorial ambitions there were thwarted by an alliance between Holland, England, and Sweden. In 1672, having detached England from that alliance, he invaded Holland, but under William of Orange the Dutch managed to stand firm against him. Although this campaign led to the formation of another European alliance against France, Louis did make some territorial gains along France’s frontiers.

In 1688 he was at war again, against a “Grand Alliance” that included Holland and England, both now ruled by William of Orange. A factor in this alliance for the Protestant member states was Louis’ revocation of the Edict of Nantes in 1685 (see pp.258–59), which meant that Huguenots (French Protestants) no longer had the right to practice their faith in France. The War of the Grand Alliance lasted until 1697. There were a few years of peace until 1700, when the death

of the king of Spain led to the War of the Spanish Succession (see right).

To fund his constant military campaigns, Louis XIV relied on his director of finances, Jean-Baptiste Colbert. Colbert improved the tax collection system, brought

The Sun King portrait

This magnificent portrait by Hyacinthe Rigaud of the “Sun King” fits contemporary descriptions of Louis XIV. By all accounts, Louis was attractive, with a strong nose, piercing eyes, and a healthy complexion.



Royal family tree

Louis XIV was a member of one of the most powerful and widely distributed royal dynasties in Europe, the Bourbons. His mother, Anne of Austria, was a member of another great dynasty of the period: the Habsburgs.

